Start-of-year check: letter names and sounds, sound games · lesson 2 of 2 · 50 minutes

Start-of-Year Check 2: Letter Sounds and First Sounds

Today your child learns: I show the letter sounds I know, and I listen for the first sound in a word.



Standards: RF.K.1d, RF.K.3a, RF.K.3b, RF.K.2, RF.K.1a. Common Core State Standards © 2010 NGA Center and CCSSO.

5′ Sounds · 15′ Check · 10′ Check · 10′ Read · 10′ Check

Today at a glance

5 min	Warm-up: Jump or Sit rhyme game, unscored, no letters, no drill.
15 min	Letter-sound check: 26 small letters on the day 6 card, tick sounds, /26.
10 min	First-sound check: model van, practice key, score pizza nose leg web gate, /5.
10 min	Story time: child picks a book, points where reading starts and goes next.
10 min	Record six totals on the Class Tracker; lowest band picks tomorrow's help.

Get ready (2 minutes)

- Print: Sound Check: First Sound
- Print: Class Tracker
- Print: How to Read the Check
- Small-letter card and record sheet from day 6 (reuse, do not reprint)
- Pencil and a picture book

Printing in black and white? The green start dot is the big dot.

Tip for the grown-up

In class, give both checks one child at a time across the day, 5 to 8 minutes each, while others reuse the trace pages, find-the-letter pages and Roll and Cover from days 1-5; at home it is one sitting of about 20 minutes. Never teach or correct during a check, and praise effort, not answers.



Short on time? At home in 20 minutes

1. Warm up for 2 minutes with Jump or Sit: jump when two words rhyme (mat, sat) and sit when they don't (map, sun).
2. Letter sounds (6 minutes): point to each letter on the day 6 small-letter card, ask "What sound?", and tick right answers on the day 6 record sheet without correcting.
3. First sound (4 minutes): model van, practice key, then ask the first sound of pizza, nose, leg, web and gate and tick each right one out of 5.
4. Read your child's favorite book for 5 minutes as a thank-you, letting them point to where you start each page.
5. Later (3 minutes), copy the totals onto the Class Tracker and use How to Read the Check: the lowest band picks the help.



SOUND GAMES

Warm-up: Jump or Sit

5 min

Relax and wake up the ears with an unscored rhyme game. No letters and no letter drill today.

Watch me I do it, you watch

SAY

Let's wake up our ears. This is just for fun.

Mat, sat. Same end. They rhyme, so I jump!

Top, sun. Different ends. No rhyme, so I sit.

- Stand facing the child. Jump on a rhyme pair. Sit down on a no-rhyme pair.
- Say each word slowly and lean on the end a little: maaat, saaat.

We do together

SAY

Jump with me if they rhyme. Sam, ham.

Sit with me if they don't. Map, sock.

Am, jam. Jump or sit?

- Jump or sit together on each pair.
- Smile and keep it quick. Nothing is written down in this part.

You do the child alone

SAY

Your turn alone. Mat, hat.

Map, sun.

Top, mop.

- The child jumps or sits alone. Praise effort: "Great listening!"
- After 3 pairs, sit side by side at the table for the check.

If your child gets it wrong

- Say: "My turn: mat, hat. Same end. Jump! Our turn: jump. Your turn: mat, hat."
- Keep it light. No notes and no marks.



CHECK

Letter-Sound Check

15 min

Find out which of the 26 small-letter sounds the child knows, without teaching. Score out of 26. In class: one child at a time, 5 to 8 minutes each, spread across the day; the others work on pages from days 1 to 5.

Watch me I do it, you watch

SAY

I point to a letter. You tell me the sound it makes, like /sh/.

/sh/, the baby is sleeping. Not the letter name, just /sh/.

Some you know, some you will learn soon. That is just fine.

- Sit side by side. Day 6 small-letter card faces the child; record sheet on your lap.
- Explain with /sh/ only. Do not point to or say any letter on the card.

We do together

SAY

Make a train sound with me: /ch/ /ch/ /ch/.

Tell me the sound, like /ch/. You can say "pass" any time.

Ready? Here is the first one.

- Make the train sound together, arms chugging, then sit still and ready.
- Put your pointer finger under the first letter on the card.

You do the child alone

SAY

What sound does this letter make?

Thank you. Next one.

You worked so hard. High five!

- Point to each letter in card order. Wait 3 seconds. Tick each right sound.
- c: /k/ or /s/. g: /g/ or /j/. Vowels: count the short sound (/a/ as in apple).

If your child gets it wrong

- Letter name instead (ay)? Say once: "That is its name. What sound does it make?" Wrong or no answer: no tick, no correction, "Thanks, next one."
- Count stop sounds like /b/ or /d/ even with a small "uh": they are hard to say alone.



CHECK

First-Sound Check

10 min

Find out if the child can hear and say the first sound in a spoken word. Score out of 5.

Watch me I do it, you watch

SAY

Now a listening game. I say a word, you tell me its first sound.

Listen: van. /v/ /v/ van. The first sound in van is /v/.

- Hold the Sound Check: First Sound sheet so only you see it. The child sees no letters.
- Hold the /v/ a little: vvv. No "uh" after it.

We do together

SAY

Say key together. What is the first sound? /k/.

Yes, /k/.

- Say key together, then the sound together. Practice words are never scored.
- Still unsure? Model key once more, then start the scored words.

You do the child alone

SAY

Your turn alone. Pizza. What is the first sound?

Next word: nose. What is the first sound?

All done! Super listening ears.

- Then ask the same way for leg, web and gate. Say each word at most twice.
- Tick right sounds: /p/, /n/, /l/, /w/, /g/. Write the total out of 5.

If your child gets it wrong

- Letter name instead? Ask once: "What sound?" Count /g/ even with a small "uh".
- Wrong or no answer: no tick, no teaching. Say "Thanks!" and give the next word.



READING TOGETHER

Story Time: Where Do I Read?

10 min

Enjoy a thank-you story and show that we read left to right, top to bottom.

Watch me I do it, you watch

SAY

You worked so hard. You pick the book, I read!

I read left to right. At the end of a line, I sweep back and down.

- Child picks any picture book. Run your finger under each line as you read.
- At each line's end, sweep your finger back to the left, one line down.

We do together

SAY

Put your finger on mine. Let's sweep together.

Where do I start on this page?

- Read two pages with both fingers moving under the words.
- Pause at the top of a new page and let the child point to the start.

You do the child alone

SAY

Show me where I start reading.

Show me where I go after this line.

Which page do I read next: this one or that one?

- The child points; you read on. Do this on 3 or 4 pages, not every page.
- In class, read to the whole group and invite 2 or 3 children up to point.

If your child gets it wrong

- Say: "My turn: I start here, top left. Our turn: point with me. Your turn: show me."
- At a line's end: "My turn: back and down. Our turn. Your turn."

CHECK

Record and Plan

10 min

Put both days' totals on the Class Tracker and choose each child's help with one band table.

Watch me I do it, you watch

SAY

Thank you for working so hard today. I'm writing a note to help me teach.

- Copy totals to the Class Tracker: Capitals, Small, Sounds, Rhyme, Syllables, First sound.
- Find each total's band on How to Read the Check: Got it, Nearly or Not yet.

We do together

SAY

Tell me your favorite part of today while I write.

- Let the child chat or look at the book while you work.
- Use the band of the lowest part to choose the help. Write it in the Group column.

You do the child alone

SAY

Tomorrow we play a new listening game. See you then!

- Follow the Got it / Nearly / Not yet boxes below to choose each child's help.
- In class, sort the tracker into three groups by band before tomorrow's lesson.

If your child gets it wrong

- A total looks odd (tired, upset, shy)? Recheck just that part on another day, kindly and briefly.
- Never share scores in front of the child; praise effort only.

Quick check (2 minutes)

1. Letter sounds: the child says the sound of each small letter on the day 6 card, out of 26 (Got it 18 to 26, Nearly 8 to 17, Not yet 0 to 7).
2. First sound: pizza, nose, leg, web, gate after practice with van and key, out of 5 (Got it 4 or 5, Nearly 2 or 3, Not yet 0 or 1).
3. Copy all six totals from days 6 and 7 onto the Class Tracker and use the band of the lowest part to choose the help.

Got it

Lowest part in Got it: Keeps pace with the daily lessons. On review days, give a challenge: read am and at early, or find the first sound in friends' names.

Nearly

Lowest part in Nearly: Daily lessons plus 3 extra minutes with index cards (on a ring) of only the letters and sounds the child missed: say each one, then its key picture.

Not yet

Lowest part in Not yet: Daily lessons plus 5 extra minutes (in class a small group; at home just you and your child): 2 or 3 letters at a time, name, sound and key picture, with sound games. Check again in 4 weeks.